

Wired, October 2004

Presenting The Digital Photo Future

WITH MILLIONS OF pictures being shot everyday by lakhs of people worldwide, thanks to the flexibility provided by digital cameras, where would these digital memories be stored? Enter digital photo archiving. In this excerpt from Wired magazine, writer David Weinberger of Wired demystifies the future for us.

A digital camera is an enticement to take more snaps than you can keep track of. You don't even need to carry a camera; you can squeeze off a stream of shots with your cell phone and send them to your inbox. With the price of digital storage plummeting even as our time seems to become ever more valuable, it's cheaper to store the lot of them than to weed out the clunkers.

But having thousands of photos on a hard disk or DVD-ROM is the equivalent of throwing Bettmann's images (a photo archiving company that stores millions of photographs) into the air and letting them flutter to the ground. Our only hope is that the army of engineers laboring in labs around the world can come up with a better way.

The situation at the Bettmann Archive may be discouraging, but Corbis, a stock photo house that happens to be Bettmann's corporate owner, is groping toward a solution. For one thing, the 3.2 million images stored in Corbis' Seattle headquarters have been digitized. For another, they're being annotated with keywords that make it possible for customers to log on to the company's Web site, sift through more than 62 terabytes of photo data, and pinpoint images that meet their needs.

Inside the company's airy office, media cataloger Nick Fraser sits in front of two screens. On the right is a photo of a strawberry, perfectly lit and very red. On the left is an in-house software app that lets him browse through a list of keywords. Fraser's job is to tag images with appropriate terms so that when customers search using a keyword, they find photos that match. Fraser's palette offers 60,000 choices, arranged in a hierarchy; the top level is the "Top of the World." Under the category unaccountably called "Anatomy," he clicks on "Fruit." He adds "Red," and the photo is tagged.

A photo of a businessman sitting in a small chair facing two other chairs of increasing size is harder to tag. It is vague and evocative. Deciding what words to use means figuring out what the photo might mean to others: Decisionmaking? Disappointment? Downsizing? There is no right answer. "You just have to look at it long enough to see what the metaphor is," Fraser says.

In computer parlance, these tags are metadata - information about information. But metadata as it relates to imagery is a slippery thing, and tagging is a craft, not a science.

To read the complete article, visit www.snipurl.com/photofuture



Wired, October 2004

The World of Halo 2

DAVID KUSHNER OF Wired magazine walks us through the offices of Bungie Studios, the company behind Halo 2, the world's most anticipated game.

"Behold!" proclaims Pete Parsons, manager - Bungie Studios, as he steps into the game company's most exclusive room. "We call this the LRS."

The living room simulator is where Bungie's developers are beta-testing the year's most anticipated videogame, Halo 2.

The original Halo, a first-person shooter released for the Xbox in 2001, dazzled the gaming world with its cinematic sweep. Taking a page from the movies, it featured car chase scenes, stunning locations, and smart sci-fi suspense. It sold more than 4 million copies, making it the biggest Xbox blockbuster yet.

Halo 2 brought down the house in May at E3, the videogame industry's mammoth trade show. It garnered the most award nominations and won Best Console Game, Best Action Game, and Best Online Multiplayer Game - and that was just for the demo.

Now, with only a few weeks of production time left before Halo 2's November 9 release, the LRS looks more like an abused frat lounge than the incubator for a multimillion-dollar game.

When Bungie designers began working on Halo 2 in 2001, they quickly realized that making a new game for an old console (the Xbox turns three this year) requires that you tap human power rather than the latest videocard or motherboard. So they took the moviemaking idea behind Halo one step further and staffed their development team like a full-blown Hollywood production. An architect designed the sets. A thespian wrote the script. A composer penned the score.

The result: a meticulously engineered, gorgeously textured, and explosively fun game that feels like your own damn action flick. In fact, at some movie theaters this summer, the Halo 2 teaser drew wild applause. Here's a look at some of the creatives who toiled behind the scenes.

"This is bullshit!" barks Joe Staten, Cinematics Director, as he twitches in his chair. He isn't complaining about a bug in the code, he's reciting one of the 17,000 lines of dialog he wrote for Halo 2. (The script is 10 times longer than the first



game's.) This particular outburst comes when a player's rocket launcher gets stolen by another player, who swaps it for a far wimpier weapon - a stunt you couldn't pull off in the original game.

Want to read the entire feature? Visit www.snipurl.com/halo2team